

with a decent number of included amenities. KOA Campgrounds (koa.com) are a good example. They have tree-canopied campsites with electricity and water, fire pits and picnic tables, swimming pools, clean showers with changing areas, laundry, high-speed wireless service, and more. You'll be able to get away to a simplified environment without having to "rough it" to the extreme. Bonus? It's an excellent litmus test for how you'll problem-solve as a couple.



7. Couples massage, DIY style

We actually own a professional massage table. As necessities go, this would not be at the top of many couples' lists. But it's one of my favorite indulgences, and with the treatments I like to get, the massage table paid for itself within three uses. While it's not my husband's favorite vacation activity, he does occasionally indulge for relaxation. What we found, though, was that once we bought the table and the spa cost of a massage was no longer an issue, we enjoyed them more and indulged more often. It's a great at-home date that's way more of an intimacy builder than movie night.

In terms of cost, the table is really the largest expense of a home massage

setup. If you decide to incorporate this as a regular part of your dating routine, upgrades such as hot stones, face-rest pillow covers, and essential oils for homemade massage products are all easily incorporated into your budget. It also provides an overall gift theme for things you can pick up for each other affordably, such as soothing

background music, massage instructional videos for special techniques, etc. Toss in a few affordable bathroom upgrades, and you'll have an at-home spa in no time.

8. Photo shoot

If you each have a digital camera, fantastic. If not, it's an excellent opportunity to promote greater intimacy through sharing. Pick a place that's ripe with photo opportunities and take playful shots of each other and the area in general. Remote waterfall, picturesque piazza, hip downtown historic district . . . you get the idea. Incorporate lunch or a brown-bag picnic. Review your photos together at the end of the day and pick your favorites to play in a digital frame. Or have a little extra creative fun by editing a travel-style photo essay together. — **Myscha Theriault**